The CERN campus itself is not, for the most part, an especially impressive place. Once you get past the glitzy public reception lobby, it has the feel of a slightly run-down industrial installation, with a mishmash of low, drab, 1960s-era buildings with dark metal-shuttered windows. Each prominently numbered building houses its own lab or research group, the offices labeled with temporary paper nameplates to accommodate the constantly shuffling scientific staff. Across the entire campus, the physicists permanently employed by CERN number less than a hundred, with the rest of the labs and offices occupied by the thousands of visiting researchers from around the world, spending anywhere from a week to a few years carrying out the intense on-site work necessary to keep large-scale experiments running. Walking down the long dim hallways of one of these buildings, you might forget you're at the most famous experimental facility in the world, and imagine yourself in the physics department of any ordinary university, peeking in at grad students and postdoctoral researchers tapping away at laptops, or scribbling equations and work schedules on whiteboards.

When you see the experiments, though, that illusion of normalcy is swiftly and permanently broken.

My own visit to CERN was divided between the organization's two extremes. On some days, I was quietly ensconced in a bright second-floor office in the theory department, reading papers and taking breaks in the tea room to sketch out equations and chat with the other theorists about vacuum decay and my own research on dark matter. On other days, I was wearing a hardhat, 100 meters underground, standing on a metal walkway and gawking at a 25-meter-tall heavily instrumented cylinder of unimaginably complex machinery. The experiments at CERN are some of the most advanced and precise machines ever created by humanity, designed and built by teams of thousands over decades in order to tease out tiny changes in the motions and energies of particles that decay within microseconds. Meanwhile, theorists try to extract from equations of comparable but abstract complexity the implications of these experiments for the nature of space and the cosmos itself. It's a heady place.

It is also, however, an intensely bureaucratic place, being an institute governed by international treaties and run by a coalition of twenty-three different countries while hosting researchers from every corner of the planet. This kind of cooperation is necessary for an effort of such magnitude and expense, but the upshot of CERN's organizational structure